

Kansas State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-35 baseline with an eight-win center, but unusually dependent on a rebuilt offensive line and a defense replacing several high-volume contributors.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked, 0 votes · SP+ No. 34
Returning production	58% (No. 40) overall · Off. 65% (No. 23) · Def. 51% (No. 74)
Primer power rating	+9.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.1 wins · most likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Slightly better, with a wider range
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Collin Klein will call an offense built around returning QB Avery Johnson, a true three-back group and a rotated receiving corps; the defense is a new-coordinator rebuild around DE Wendell Gregory and a smaller returning core. The season turns on whether the offensive line can become functional quickly enough to let the established quarterback/backfield advantage matter.

Bottom line: Kansas State has a favorable schedule and a credible top-35 baseline, but the Wildcats are much easier to trust at quarterback and running back than in the trenches or rebuilt defensive back seven.

Beats expectations if: QB Avery Johnson makes the new Klein-led offense efficient on passing downs, the three-back rotation keeps the run game ahead of schedule, and a patchwork OL stabilizes despite the OL Pastore/OL Fitzpatrick losses.

Disappoints if: The OL turnover recreates the 2025 negative-play/third-down problems and the defense cannot replace lost tackling and secondary volume under a completely new staff.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Avery Johnson is the established returning starter; only the backup-QB job is open.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The offensive line is the defining risk: multiple 2025 starters departed, and OL John Pastore plus OL George Fitzpatrick are out for 2026.
- 3 Backfield:** RB Joe Jackson returns after 911 rushing yards and shares a coach-identified three-back group with RB Jay Harris and RB Rodney Fields Jr.
- 4 ★ DE Wendell Gregory:** DE Wendell Gregory arrives with Big 12 preseason first-team and Bednarik recognition, but the defense returns only 51% of production (No. 74).
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ gives Kansas State the No. 69 schedule and 8.1 projected wins, so failing to reach the bowl-plus range would require real underperformance.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	6-6 (5-5 Big 12)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	29.4 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	370.1 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	171.3 YPG · 5.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	6.95 YPA · 18 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	37.4%	● Below average
Scoring defense	26.7 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	386.2 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	163.8 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	222.4 YPG · 6.83 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Very good

Kansas State's 6-6 profile was mostly middle-of-the-pack on both sides. The clearest split was a strong pass-efficiency defense offset by weak third-down offense and below-average run defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+3.69 · No. 36	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.032 · No. 55	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	41.3% · No. 89	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	13.3% · No. 40	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	17.3% · No. 110	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.58 · No. 35	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.057 · No. 42	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	40.0% · No. 46	● Good / above average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.6% · No. 83	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	16.1% · No. 59	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Kansas State’s 2025 play-level profile was better than its record and traditional yardage ranks: both opponent-adjusted units were top-36, but the offense lived too much on explosives rather than down-to-down success and allowed too much havoc. That makes the rebuilt OL the clearest 2026 statistical hinge.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play caller	◆ Collin Klein - from Texas A&M; offensive play-caller	● ↑ Klein brings offensive upside, but a new staff and new call structure add transition risk.
OC	◆ Sean Gleeson - from Missouri	● ↔ A new coordinator adds transition risk while the offense changes systems.
DC/DB	◆ Jordan Peterson - from Texas A&M	● ↔ A new defensive staff takes over a low-continuity unit, increasing early transition risk.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Jay Harris	Oregon	● ↔ Major member of three-back rotation.
◆ RB Rodney Fields Jr.	Oklahoma State	● ↔ Significant member of three-back rotation.
◆ WR Josh Manning	Missouri	● ↔ Part of the primary receiver rotation.
◆ WR Izaiah Williams	Texas A&M	● ↔ Expected to hold a regular role in the receiver rotation.
◆ WR Brandon White	Hawai'i	● ↔ Receiver-rotation piece with return-game upside.
◆ OL Tyler Johnson	Auburn	● ↔ Competing for a spot in the rebuilt offensive-line five.
◆ OL Chase Duarte	San Diego State	● ↔ Another credible option for the rebuilt offensive-line five.

Out	To	Loss
WR Jayce Brown	LSU	● ↓ 2025 receiving-yardage leader (712) leaves.
RB Dylan Edwards	Kansas	● ↔ Meaningful 2025 rotation back leaves, but the room has been replenished.
OL Devin Vass	West Virginia	● ↓ Seven-start 2025 lineman leaves.
C Sam Hecht	NFL (Carolina), Round 5, No. 144	● ↓ Twelve-game starting center is an NFL draft loss.
OL Taylor Poitier	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Another twelve-game 2025 starter is gone.
OL Andrew Leingang	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ An additional twelve-game 2025 starter is gone.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Worse at the line, roughly replenished at the skill positions.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DE Wendell Gregory	Oklahoma State	● ↑ Most credible impact newcomer; preseason first-team All-Big 12 and Bednarik recognition.
◆ LB Mekhi Mason	Louisiana Tech	● ↔ Major competition/rotation candidate rather than a locked starter.
◆ S Adrian Maddox	Georgia	● ↔ Safety competition candidate in a rebuilt secondary.
◆ S Koy Beasley	Miami (OH)	● ↔ Another safety competition candidate in a rebuilt secondary.
◆ S Ja'Son Prevard	Virginia	● ↔ Major-role safety contender.

Out	To	Loss
LB Austin Romaine	Texas Tech	● ↓ 66-tackle 2025 contributor leaves.
LB Des Purnell	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Team-leading 72 tackles leave the linebacker room.
S VJ Payne	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 7, No. 228	● ↓ 59-tackle safety is an NFL draft loss.
DB Qua Moss	Tennessee	● ↓ 41-tackle secondary contributor leaves.
S Daniel Cobbs	Baylor	● ↓ 39-tackle safety leaves.
DL Chiddi Obiazor	Indiana	● ↓ Meaningful front rotation production leaves.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Likely worse initially; portal additions must replace a large amount of tackling and secondary/front experience.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Klein-called offense with an established quarterback, a three-back rotation and a deliberately deep WR rotation.	Quarterback continuity, backfield depth and 2025 explosive-play ability (No.40).	Protection/negative-play consistency after severe OL turnover; 2025 success rate was No.89 and havoc allowed No.110.
Defense	New-coordinator unit rebuilding the front seven and safety/nickel combinations rather than carrying over a settled 2025 depth chart.	2025 opponent-adjusted defense No.35, EPA/play allowed No.42, success rate allowed No.46 and pass-efficiency defense No.29.	Low returning production and major tackling/secondary losses, with 2025 explosive-play prevention only No.83.
Special teams	Reliable placekicker, unsettled punter and returner.	K Luis Rodriguez returns with Groza recognition.	No final punter or returner has been established.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	High	QB Avery Johnson is the established returning starter and the offense's clearest continuity edge.
RB	● B+	● ↑	High	RB Joe Jackson leads a proven three-back rotation.
WR	● B	● ↔	Medium	WR Jaron Tibbs supplies returning production in a deliberately deep rotation.
TE	● B	● ↔	High	TE Garrett Oakley is a stable returning target.
OL	● C	● ↓	Low	Multiple starters departed, and OL John Pastore plus OL George Fitzpatrick are out for 2026.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	DE Wendell Gregory adds upside to a front that still has replacement work.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Low defensive continuity leaves a less-proven second level.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Zashon Rich returns, but major safety/DB losses lower continuity.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium	K Luis Rodriguez is settled; punter and returner remain open.
Coaching	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	Klein brings offensive upside and play-calling authority, but a new HC, OC and DC create meaningful first-year transition risk.
Overall	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	Top-35 baseline with an eight-win center and major OL/defensive turnover.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Avery Johnson	QB	● Established Power 4 starter / team ceiling driver	Maxwell	Returning starter is the clearest continuity advantage on a roster with major trench turnover.
Wendell Gregory (TR: Oklahoma State)	DE	● High-end conference impact newcomer	Big 12 preseason first team · Bednarik	Most credentialed newcomer on a defense replacing a large amount of production.
Joe Jackson	RB	● High-end conference starter/rotation lead	Maxwell	Returns after 911 rushing yards and gives the three-back room a proven center.
Jaron Tibbs	WR	● Proven returning starter	-	Returns 47 catches and 595 yards after the 2025 receiving-yardage leader transferred.
Garrett Oakley	TE	● Proven receiving tight end	John Mackey	Returns 38 catches for 389 yards and gives a rebuilt offense another stable target.
Zashon Rich	CB	● Key returning secondary anchor	-	Returns after 57 tackles while multiple safeties/DBs depart.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Luis Rodriguez	K	● Stable specialist	Lou Groza	The placekicker is one of the few settled pieces in a special-teams unit with open punter/returner jobs.
John Pastore	OL	● Key unavailable player	Big 12 preseason first team · Outland	His season-ending absence compounds an already severe offensive-line rebuild.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable and favorable relative to Kansas State's top-35 baseline; the schedule creates a real path to eight or more wins if the OL is merely functional.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 69
Hardest stretch	at Colorado → Oklahoma State → at TCU → Arizona
Swing games	at Cincinnati, Houston, at Arizona State, Oklahoma State, at TCU, Arizona
Advantage	The rated schedule lacks a top-30 SP+ opponent; Washington State and Tulane also sit below Kansas State, and the bye precedes the Big 12 home run.
Expected	8.1 wins · most likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Potentially attractive when priced as a generic mid-tier Big 12 team because the schedule can let the record outpace the neutral-field rating. The harder question is whether the rebuilt trenches can beat an elite opponent if that path reaches the conference-title stage.
Back them when	The opponent cannot generate consistent pressure and Kansas State is not being asked to win through an unproven OL in obvious passing downs.
Fade/pass when	Facing strong fronts or when the market prices the offense as if the new line and new staff are already fully settled.
Key monitor	Final best-five OL, early pass-protection performance, and whether the new defense can replace lost tackling/secondary volume.
Week 1 baseline	vs. Nicholls: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Kansas State -40.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Kansas State's clearest advantage is offensive continuity at the highest-leverage spots: QB Avery Johnson returns, RB Joe Jackson leads a true three-back group, and TE Garrett Oakley/WR Jaron Tibbs provide known targets for new HC/play-caller Collin Klein. The schedule also gives a top-35 team a realistic path to eight wins.

The uncertainty is concentrated in the trenches and defense. Multiple OL starters are gone and OL John Pastore/OL George Fitzpatrick are out for the season, while defensive returning production is only **51%** under a new staff. That makes **8.1 wins / 8-4** a sensible center with meaningful downside if pass protection never settles.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [preseason camp](#) · [coordinators](#) · [HC Collin Klein](#) · [OL injuries](#) · [NFL draft exits](#)

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